FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

India may be gripped by political fervour on the streets, but on the silver screen the froth is coming from somewhere else entirely: religious faith. A film on Neem Karoli Baba, a guru who liked solitude and preferred to slip away from crowds in his lifetime, has already drawn some 20 million people to the theatres since it was released in early August. *Hanuman Ansh*, made by writer-director Vishal Chaturvedi on a shoestring budget of Rs 1.7 crore, has crossed Rs 400 crore in global earnings, and the counter is still ticking. The film's runaway success, spreading by word of mouth, has set off a cultural phenomenon beyond its own numbers. Viewers are removing their footwear to pray in cinemas, and often in tears. The guru's dham in Uttarakhand is seeing a sudden surge in footfalls and Sony has embarked on a show based around him. Above all, it's the clearest confirmation yet of where India's popular Indian cinema is headed. For the next few seasons, the gods will be doing a lot of heavy lifting at the box office.

Nowhere will the Puranas cast their glow on screen more dazzlingly than with the mega project just around the corner. Come Diwali, the star-studded *Ramayana: The Rise of a Legend (Part 1)* will hit the halls. The nth adaptation of the beloved epic, it shows the industry's willingness to bet big on faith-based dramas. Its cast boasts Ranbir Kapoor as Ram, Sai Pallavi as Sita, Sunny Deol as Hanuman and Yash as Ravan. Barring special appearances or comedic turns, this is surely the first time a mainstream Bollywood star will walk the path of southern heroes from another era in portraying a deity on screen. The two-part project's Rs 4,000 crore budget also promises the latest special effects and a music score co-written by A.R. Rahman and German composer Hans Zimmer. How the film fares will, of course, decide how long this trend will last.



▲ Apr. 22, 2013

The queue behind it is long. In 2027, *Ramayana Part 2* will be jostling for the attention of devout audiences with a spate of other contenders: the Akshaye Khanna-starrer *Mahakali* in January, for starters. February will follow up with two animation films: one on Durga and one on Hanuman, done entirely on AI. Those who miss that can catch up with regular feature films: another one on Kali, and on Hanuman, besides an animated feature on Parashuram. That's not counting films on spiritual gurus spurred by *Hanuman Ansh*. The 14th-century saint Ramdev Pir will be cinematically reborn in one of them, the other will bring to life a figure closer to our times: Devraha Baba, the one who famously blessed the devout with his feet.

Agnostics who need proof can find it at the box office. In 2025, *Mahavatar Narsimha* made nearly Rs 250 crore, unprecedented for an Indian animated film. In January, a film on Krishna became the highest grosser ever in Gujarati cinema. The logic driving the phenomenon is expressed simply by *Narsimha* director Ashwin Kumar. "If a crore people can visit Kumbh mela, you know there is a colossal mass that loves stories on faith," he says. "We just need to bring them tales they truly believe in, and do it with self-belief." The charming real-life tale of the making of *Hanuman Ansh* conforms perfectly to that. Its maker, Chaturvedi, was no industry bigwig cynically mining a trend. He is an actual devotee who turned his inner calling into a film. Neem Karoli Baba had passed on in 1973, but his Kainchi Dham stayed a pilgrim magnet. It was a path Steve Jobs trudged in 1974, as a 19-year-old hippie college dropout, and a reverence he famously passed on to Mark Zuckerberg. Chaturvedi was nowhere close to such orbits when he embarked on his venture. Finance was hard to come by, schedules were ultra-tight, and a last-minute emergency saw assistant director Shobhinaw Satyaa transform overnight into lead actor. After a flaccid first week that earned only Rs 90 lakh, the Chaturvedi-Satyaa duo travelled and met audiences in cinemas, urging them to help spread the word. What followed was a miracle worthy of Neem Karoli Baba.

Devotion is hardly a new cinematic invention. India's first feature film, Dadasaheb Phalke's *Raja Harishchandra* in 1913, was a mythological and so were his next three. In fact, of the 1,388 films made in the silent era before 1931, about 1,000 drew on our abundant pantheon of gods. The run of venerable smash hits never really ceased, from *Sant Tukaram* in 1936 to *Jai Santoshi Maa*, which gave *Sholay* a run for its money in 1975. The epic run of *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata* on Doordarshan in the 1980s, in fact, blended into an evolving political landscape. No surprise, then, that the RSS-backed Bharatiya Chitra Sadhana, created in 2016, is actively promoting films that centre dharmic themes.

But politics alone does not fill a cinema hall. As Deputy Editor Suhani Singh's cover story shows, what drives this is an audience already primed to believe. The characters our grandmothers brought alive at bedtime now arrive in surround sound and modern graphics. The devotion is old. The spectacle married to the magic of movies is new. But the money is very real. We have a name for it: HOLYWOOD.

(Aroon Purie)